



Fiery duel: A Kalaripayattu duel at the Khelo India Youth Games.

R. SELVAMUTHUKUMAR

sportspersons. Khelo India Centers have come up in many cities and disciplines. For betterment, I suggest SAI hold a 3-week or a 6-week camp and send the players for exposure tours to foreign countries. It will definitely yield results," he said.

K. K. Mukundan, former National swimming coach, said it is hard to find any loopholes as far as the swimming organisation was concerned at KIYG. "I can't find any. It was near-perfect. I wish they maintain the facilities and continue to do a good job," he said.

A renovated velodrome for cycling at TNPESU was a welcome addition to the Games and proved that the sport has a future in the State.

Maninderpal Singh, Secretary of the Cycling Federation of India, said that KIYG is a good initiative as it sees participants come from remote parts of India. "The Velodrome in Chennai is a big boost to cyclists from TN.

Moreover, cyclists from TN did well in certain sections, especially in the girls' category. We have 14 velodromes in

India including the one in TNPESU. It will go a long way in promoting cycling," he said.

Former India hockey captain, Md. Riaz, also said, "KIYG is a great platform for youngsters to showcase their skills. It gives them the feeling of being in the Olympics or Asian Games." Riaz suggested the weaker teams in hockey be supported by the Central Government in terms of funding and help the respective States in whatever way it can. "That way, we can improve the quality of

the teams and the quality of competition," said the Olympian.

Maintenance and upkeep of stadiums, fair selection and constant monitoring of those selected in SAI/SDAT programmes are important considerations going forward.

The fact remains that KIYG remains a benchmark in terms of organisational excellence on many parameters.

As Anurag Thakur, Union Minister for Youth Affairs & Sports, rightly said at the closing ceremony of the Games, "Well done, TN".



Leaders assemble: Anurag Thakur (L), Union Minister of Youth Affairs & Sports, and Udhayanidhi Stalin (R), Tamil Nadu Sports Minister, greet each other during the closing ceremony. PTI